

Two-Year Reading Curriculum

*Literature · Philosophy · History · Sciences · Mathematics ·
Buddhist Philosophy · Technology*

Built from your library. Starting where you already are.

~**2.5 years** total **2 hrs** daily reading ~**40** deep reads ~**90** substantial

~**150** encounter texts **Science track** woven throughout

COLOUR KEY

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| ● Currently reading — continue & finish | ● Tier I — Deep read, full attention (3-6 weeks) |
| ● Tier II — Substantial, full text (1-3 weeks) | ● Tier III — Encounter, key selections (days) |
| ● Tier IV — Dip, always available, no schedule | ● Science track — integrated throughout |
| ● Tech track — parallel, daily 20-30 min | ● Buddhist strand — parallel, daily |

The Science Curriculum

*The great universities of the 20th century — Chicago, Harvard, Oxford, Caltech — required all students regardless of major to engage with the primary texts of science. Not popular summaries, but **the actual books that changed how***

humanity understood itself and the natural world. *This is that curriculum, rebuilt from your library and supplemented with the classic texts that belong alongside it. The science track runs as a parallel strand — one science book always in progress alongside the main literary curriculum, roughly one per month.*

Evolution, Natural History & Biology

Darwin is the anchor — primary text, not summary. Everything else in biology and ecology is a response to or extension of the argument Darwin made in 1859. The great field naturalists come next: Gilbert White inventing ecology before the word existed, Audubon and Peterson transforming how we see birds, E.O. Wilson synthesizing everything.

CHARLES DARWIN — TIER I · READ IN Q5 (YEAR TWO)

The Origin of Species

Harvard, Chicago, and Oxford all required this as a primary text — not for biology students but for everyone. The argument is one of the great achievements of human prose reasoning. Read the Introduction, Chapters I, III, IV, and XIV at minimum. Chapter XIV's conclusion is the most quietly devastating ending in English scientific prose. "There is grandeur in this view of life..."

RICHARD DAWKINS — TIER I · READ IN Q5 ALONGSIDE DARWIN

The Selfish Gene

Published 1976, instantly canonical. Dawkins reformulates Darwinian evolution at the level of the gene rather than the organism and introduces the concept of the meme. The finest work of science writing of the late 20th century. Read Darwin first, then Dawkins — the conversation between them is the education.

E.O. WILSON — TIER II · Q6

On Human Nature · The Diversity of Life

Wilson's Pulitzer-winning synthesis of evolutionary biology and human behaviour. *On Human Nature* (1978) asks the hardest question: what does evolution imply about ethics, religion, and the meaning of human existence? *The Diversity of Life* is his great ecological work — the most eloquent account of what we are losing.

ERNST MAYR — TIER II · Q6

What Evolution Is

Mayr was the greatest evolutionary biologist of the 20th century. This late summary (2001) is the clearest account of what evolution actually is — written for the intelligent general reader after a lifetime of research. Read after Darwin and Dawkins to consolidate.

STEPHEN JAY GOULD — TIER III · DIP THROUGHOUT

The Panda's Thumb · Ever Since Darwin

Gould's collected essays — the best science essays written in English since Huxley. Pull these out whenever the longer books feel too dense. Each essay is complete and brilliant on its own.

FRANCIS CRICK — TIER III · Q6

What Mad Pursuit · The Double Helix (Watson)

The discovery of DNA as personal narrative. Watson's account is more dramatic and controversial; Crick's is more reflective. Read both for the inside view of how science actually works — ambition, competition, luck, and genuine insight.

Ecology, Natural History & the Literature of Place

The great tradition of natural history writing is as much literature as science. Gilbert White's Selborne (1789) invented ecology before Darwin. Thoreau's Walden invented environmental consciousness. Rachel Carson's Silent Spring changed the world. These books belong alongside Montaigne and Emerson — they are essays in the fullest sense.

GILBERT WHITE — TIER I · Q3 (READ ALONGSIDE THE ANCIENTS)

The Natural History of Selborne

Published 1789. The founding text of modern ecology — and one of the most beautiful books in English prose. A curate in a Hampshire village observing the natural world for thirty years with inexhaustible patience and curiosity. Virginia Woolf loved it. Keats read it. Darwin said it taught him how to observe. One letter per day alongside the primary reading.

ALDO LEOPOLD — TIER I · Q4

A Sand County Almanac

The founding text of modern environmental ethics. Leopold invented the concept of "the land ethic" — the idea that human beings have moral obligations to the natural community, not just to other people. Required reading in ecology, philosophy, and environmental studies at every major university since its publication in 1949. The most important environmental book ever written.

RACHEL CARSON — TIER I · Q7

Silent Spring · The Sea Around Us

Silent Spring (1962) launched the modern environmental movement — one book that changed government policy, public consciousness, and the fate of species. The Sea Around Us won the National Book Award and is Carson at her most lyrical. Both required reading in the great university curricula after 1962.

HENRY DAVID THOREAU — TIER II · Q2

Walden

The foundational text of American environmental consciousness. Thoreau spent two years in a cabin by a pond and transformed the experience into the most influential piece of American prose after the founding documents. Read it slowly — one chapter per day alongside the Greeks. It is also philosophy: how to live, what is essential, what can be discarded.

HENRY BESTON — TIER II · Q3

The Outermost House

A year alone in a dune cottage on Cape Cod, 1928. The finest book of nature writing in the American tradition after Thoreau. Required at many New England universities through the 1970s. "The world today is sick to its thin blood for lack of elemental things."

KONRAD LORENZ — TIER II · Q5

King Solomon's Ring · On Aggression

Lorenz won the Nobel Prize for his work on animal behaviour (ethology). King Solomon's Ring is the most charming science book of the 20th century — Lorenz writing about jackdaws, geese, and dogs with the combination of rigour and affection that only the greatest naturalists achieve. On Aggression is the harder, more

controversial book: animal aggression and what it implies about human violence.

BERND HEINRICH — TIER II · Q6

Mind of the Raven · A Year in the Maine Woods

Heinrich is the heir to both Lorenz and Thoreau — a biologist who can write. *Mind of the Raven* is his masterpiece: fifteen years studying raven intelligence. *A Year in the Maine Woods* is his *Walden*. Both required in natural history courses at major universities from the 1990s onward.

JOHN MUIR — TIER III · DIP THROUGHOUT

My First Summer in the Sierra · The Mountains of California

The founding texts of the American conservation movement. Muir's prose at its best is rapturous — the Sierra Nevada as religious experience, ecological observation as devotion. Dip in whenever you need air.

ROBERT MACFARLANE — TIER III · DIP

The Wild Places · Mountains of the Mind

The finest living writer in the British natural history tradition. Macfarlane writes about landscape with the same precision and feeling that the best novelists bring to character. Pull these in when reading about ecology becomes too abstract.

Ornithology & the Art of Observation

Ornithology is the oldest and most democratic of the natural sciences — it requires only patience, attention, and a willingness to be outside. The great ornithology books are also masterpieces of observation and description. They teach you to see.

ROGER TORY PETERSON — TIER II · BEGIN YEAR ONE

A Field Guide to the Birds

Peterson's 1934 field guide invented the modern field guide and launched the mass popular interest in birds. Not just a reference book — a philosophy of attention. Keep it with you. The practice of identifying birds is a practice in the same careful observation that

the best scientists and writers share. Use it in the field alongside anything else you are reading.

PETER MATTHIESSEN — TIER I · Q6

The Wind Birds · The Snow Leopard

The Wind Birds is Matthiessen's account of the shorebirds of the Atlantic Coast — ornithology as meditation on impermanence and migration. *The Snow Leopard* is his masterpiece: a journey into the Himalaya in search of the snow leopard, and a journey into grief, Buddhism, and the nature of attention. It belongs simultaneously in the science strand and the Buddhist strand.

J.A. BAKER — TIER I · ANY QUARTER

The Peregrine

Published 1967. The greatest work of ornithology ever written — and one of the great works of English prose, full stop. Baker spent ten years following peregrine falcons across the Essex landscape and wrote a book of extraordinary intensity. Robert Macfarlane calls it "one of the finest nature books ever written." Werner Herzog considers it essential reading for filmmakers. Read it in autumn, outdoors when possible.

AUDUBON — TIER III · ENCOUNTER

The Birds of America — Selected Plates + Ornithological Biography

Audubon's great plates are visual documents of the natural world at a moment before industrial transformation. The Ornithological Biography — the text that accompanies the plates — is extraordinary nature writing. Encounter the plates in a library edition if possible.

MARK COCKER — TIER III

Birds Britannica · Crow Country

Cocker is the great historian of human relationships with birds. *Birds Britannica* is encyclopedic; *Crow Country* is a sustained meditation on rooks and landscape. Both teach you how to look.

Anthropology & Human Origins

Anthropology was required at every major university from the 1920s through the 1970s as the essential supplement to history — it asks what human beings are across cultures and time, rather than within a single tradition. The foundational texts remain essential.

JAMES GEORGE FRAZER — TIER I · Q4

The Golden Bough — Abridged Edition

*The most influential work of comparative anthropology ever written. Frazer collected the myths, rituals, and magical beliefs of cultures across the world and showed their underlying structural similarities — the dying and rising god, the scapegoat, the sacred king. Eliot used it to write *The Waste Land*. Joyce used it to write *Ulysses*. Required at every major university 1900–1970. Read the abridged edition; it is still enormous and magnificent.*

CLAUDE LÉVI-STRAUSS — TIER I · Q6

Tristes Tropiques

The most beautiful book ever written by an anthropologist. Lévi-Strauss's account of his fieldwork among the indigenous peoples of Brazil — and simultaneously a meditation on civilization, modernity, and the vanishing of the world. Sartre called it "the most beautiful book of the second half of the 20th century." Required at Paris, Cambridge, and Harvard from the 1950s.

RUTH BENEDICT — TIER II · Q5

Patterns of Culture

Benedict's 1934 masterwork arguing that cultures, like individuals, have distinct personalities and that no culture's values are universal. One of the most important books of the 20th century for breaking down cultural parochialism. Required at American universities from the 1930s through the 1970s.

BRONISŁAW MALINOWSKI — TIER II · Q5

Argonauts of the Western Pacific

The founding text of modern participant-observation fieldwork. Malinowski spent two years in the Trobriand Islands and produced a detailed account of the Kula exchange system that transformed anthropology. Required at Oxford and Cambridge from the 1920s.

E.E. EVANS-PRITCHARD — TIER II · Q5

Witchcraft, Oracles and Magic Among the Azande

The classic of British social anthropology. Evans-Pritchard shows how the Azande system of belief in witchcraft is internally consistent and rational — a devastating challenge to Western assumptions of cognitive superiority. Required at Oxford from the 1930s.

DESMOND MORRIS — TIER III · Q4

The Naked Ape

Morris's 1967 popular account of human beings as a species of primate — examining courting, rearing, fighting, feeding, and comfort-seeking through the lens of zoology. A bestseller that changed how educated people thought about human nature. Read alongside E.O. Wilson.

JARED DIAMOND — TIER II · Q7

Guns, Germs and Steel

Diamond's Pulitzer Prize-winning account of why some civilizations came to dominate others — not through racial or intellectual superiority but through geographical accidents of domesticable plants and animals, navigable rivers, and continental orientation. One of the most important books of popular science of the late 20th century.

RICHARD WRANGHAM — TIER III · Q7

Catching Fire: How Cooking Made Us Human

Wrangham's argument that cooking — not tool use or language — is the defining adaptation of the human species. Recent science that belongs with the classical anthropology.

Physics, Cosmology & Mathematics

Every educated person in the 20th century was expected to understand, at a conceptual level, what Newton achieved, what Einstein revised, and what quantum mechanics implies. Not to solve the equations — but to understand the argument. The books below make this possible without a mathematics degree.

RICHARD FEYNMAN — TIER I · Q5

*The Feynman Lectures on Physics — Vol. I
(selected chapters) · Surely You're Joking, Mr.
Feynman!*

Feynman's Lectures are the greatest work of physics pedagogy ever produced. Vol. I (mechanics, radiation, heat) — read Chapters 1–6 and you will understand what physics is trying to do and why it is beautiful. Surely You're Joking is the autobiography — the most enjoyable science book of the 20th century. Required at Caltech and imitated everywhere.

ALBERT EINSTEIN — TIER II · Q5

Relativity: The Special and General Theory

Einstein's own popular exposition, written for the general reader. The argument that space and time are not absolute but relative to the observer — explained by the man who discovered it, in language that does not require calculus. Required at Chicago and Harvard as a primary text in their general education programmes.

GEORGE GAMOW — TIER II · Q6

*One Two Three... Infinity · Mr. Tompkins in
Paperback*

Gamow was the greatest populariser of physics in the mid-20th century. One Two Three... Infinity covers mathematics, physics, biology and cosmology with extraordinary range. Mr. Tompkins makes relativity and quantum mechanics tangible through a series of dreams. Both were standard texts in 20th century university general education.

STEPHEN HAWKING — TIER II · Q7

A Brief History of Time

The best-selling science book of the late 20th century — and a genuine work of popular science that delivers what it promises. Black holes, the Big Bang, the arrow of time, the possibility of a unified theory. Read after Einstein and Feynman for the context.

G.H. HARDY — TIER I · Q3

A Mathematician's Apology

The most beautiful short book about mathematics ever written. Hardy — one of the greatest mathematicians of the 20th century — defends pure mathematics as an art form, not a utility. Written in 1940 when Hardy felt his mathematical powers fading. Required at

Cambridge. Essential for understanding what mathematics is and why anyone would devote a life to it.

EUCLID — TIER I · Q2

Elements — Books I, II, VI, XI

Chicago's Great Books program required Euclid as primary text alongside Homer and Plato. The reason: Euclid's Elements is the model for all rigorous reasoning — the demonstration that you can begin from simple axioms and derive, by pure logic, results of astonishing complexity and beauty. Books I and II (plane geometry) are the essential reading. Lincoln taught himself Euclid by candlelight to learn how to construct an argument.

RICHARD COURANT & HERBERT ROBBINS — TIER II · Q4

What Is Mathematics?

The classic introduction to mathematics for the intelligent non-specialist. Einstein recommended it. Required in many university general education programmes. Covers number theory, geometry, topology, functions, limits, and the calculus — not as techniques to memorise but as ideas to understand.

GEORGE PÓLYA — TIER II · Q3

How to Solve It

Pólya's 1945 guide to mathematical problem-solving — but really a guide to thinking. The heuristics Pólya describes (understand the problem, draw a diagram, find a related problem you can solve) apply equally to writing, to engineering, to diagnosis. Required at Stanford for decades.

HENRI POINCARÉ — TIER III · Q5

Science and Hypothesis · The Value of Science

Poincaré was the last great mathematician to work across every field of mathematics simultaneously. These essays on the nature and philosophy of science were required reading at the grandes écoles and influenced Einstein directly. Brief, penetrating, essential.

History & Philosophy of Science

Chicago, Harvard, and Oxford all required a course in the history of science — not as history of technology but as intellectual history:

how did human beings change their fundamental ideas about the natural world? Kuhn's Structure of Scientific Revolutions is the most cited academic book of the 20th century.

THOMAS KUHN — TIER I · Q6

The Structure of Scientific Revolutions

The most cited academic book of the 20th century. Kuhn introduced the concept of the paradigm shift — the idea that science does not progress smoothly but through revolutionary discontinuities in which one framework of understanding is overthrown by another. Read this and you will think differently about all knowledge, not just science. Required everywhere from 1962 onward.

JACOB BRONOWSKI — TIER I · Q7

The Ascent of Man

Bronowski's 1973 companion to the BBC series is the finest popular history of science and human intellectual development ever written. From the first stone tools through Newton, Darwin, and Einstein, Bronowski traces the development of human knowledge as a continuous act of imagination. The final chapter — at Auschwitz — is one of the most devastating passages in 20th century prose.

HERBERT BUTTERFIELD — TIER II · Q5

The Origins of Modern Science

Butterfield's 1949 account of the Scientific Revolution of the 16th and 17th centuries — Copernicus, Galileo, Newton. Required at Cambridge and many American universities through the 1970s. The argument: the Scientific Revolution was not a discovery of new facts but a change in the way people thought about facts.

KARL POPPER — TIER III · Q6

The Logic of Scientific Discovery — Selected Chapters

Popper's criterion of falsifiability: a theory is scientific only if it can in principle be proved wrong. This is the sharpest philosophical account of what distinguishes science from non-science. Read Chapters 1-4 and the summary. Required at Oxford and LSE from the 1950s.

ALFRED NORTH WHITEHEAD — TIER III · Q5

Science and the Modern World

Whitehead's 1925 account of how science shaped modern thought — and where it runs into limits. Harvard required it for decades. One of the most intellectually generous books ever written: Whitehead was a mathematician who could write about poetry.

Earth Sciences, Geology & Deep Time

Darwin read Lyell's Principles of Geology on the Beagle and it transformed his thinking. The concept of deep time — geological time, billions of years — is as intellectually revolutionary as the heliocentric universe or evolution. These books give you that concept.

JOHN MCPHEE — TIER I · Q4

Annals of the Former World

McPhee's Pulitzer Prize-winning series on the geology of North America — the greatest work of science writing in the American tradition. McPhee follows geologists across the continent and explains deep time, plate tectonics, and the formation of the landscape with the narrative skill of a novelist and the rigour of a scientist. Required in geology courses and science writing programmes everywhere. Read Basin and Range as the entry point.

CHARLES LYELL — TIER III · Q3

Principles of Geology — Selected Chapters

Darwin read this on the Beagle. Lyell established that the Earth is vastly older than scripture suggested and that geological processes are uniform and ongoing — the same forces that shaped the past are shaping the present. This was the conceptual prerequisite for Darwinian evolution. Read the introduction and first five chapters.

RICHARD FORTEY — TIER II · Q5

Life: A Natural History of the First Four Billion Years

Fortey's account of the history of life on Earth from the first cells to the present. A palaeontologist who writes with the range and

pleasure of the best Victorian naturalists. Required in many natural history courses from the 1990s.

Chemistry, Medicine & the Sciences of the Body

PRIMO LEVI — TIER I · Q7

The Periodic Table

Levi was a chemist and a survivor of Auschwitz. In The Periodic Table he organizes his autobiography around the elements — each chapter named for a chemical element that shaped or illuminated an episode in his life. The most beautiful book ever written about chemistry, and one of the most beautiful memoirs in any language. It belongs simultaneously in the science strand and the literature track.

LINUS PAULING — TIER III · Q5

General Chemistry — Selected Chapters

Pauling's 1947 textbook was required at Caltech, MIT, and in science programmes at major universities for thirty years. The opening chapters on atomic structure and the nature of chemical bonds are essential conceptual reading — not problem sets, but the ideas.

OLIVER SACKS — TIER II · Q6

The Man Who Mistook His Wife for a Hat · An Anthropologist on Mars

Sacks was the greatest medical writer of the late 20th century. These case histories — neurological patients with extraordinary conditions — are simultaneously clinical documents and profound meditations on what it means to be a person. Required in medical humanities courses everywhere. Read as literature as much as science.

Ecology, Economics & the Natural World

You already have Wendell Berry, James Rebanks, and Paul Kingsnorth in your library. These belong in the science curriculum

as well as the literary one — they are the tradition of thinking about human relationships with land that runs from Gilbert White and Thoreau through Leopold and Carson to the present.

WENDELL BERRY (YOU HAVE IT) — TIER I · Q4

The World-Ending Fire — Selected Essays

Berry is the great American writer on the relationship between human communities and the land. These essays are simultaneously ecological argument, political economy, and moral philosophy. Read "The Peace of Wild Things" first — his finest poem, which is also his central argument. Read alongside Aldo Leopold.

JAMES REBANKS (YOU HAVE IT) — TIER II · Q3

English Pastoral: An Inheritance

Rebanks — a Lake District sheep farmer — has written the finest account of traditional farming and its destruction by industrial agriculture. Read alongside Gilbert White for the long view of the English landscape.

ROBERT MACFARLANE — TIER II · Q4

The Old Ways · Underland

MacFarlane's two masterpieces. The Old Ways traces ancient footpaths and the knowledge embedded in landscape. Underland goes underground — caves, mines, the deep past beneath our feet. Together they complete a vision of the natural world that Gilbert White, Thoreau, and Leopold began.

VACLAV SMIL (YOU HAVE IT) — TIER II · Q7

Energy and Civilization: A History

The most important book about the relationship between energy and human history. Smil argues that all of human history can be understood as the successive capture of new energy sources. Required reading in energy policy, economics, and environmental studies.

YOU ARE ALREADY READING THESE — DO NOT STOP

These books are in progress. Each maps onto the quarter below where they belong. You are already at Q2, Q4, and Q7 level simultaneously — your instincts are correct.

● ALL ACTIVE — CARRY FORWARD

THE BIBLE (KJV) **IN PROGRESS**

Old & New Testaments

Q1 core. Keep reading. Job → Psalms → Gospels is the right sequence.

AESCHYLUS **IN PROGRESS**

The Oresteia

Q2 core. Finish it — you are ahead of the syllabus. Read all three plays as one work.

MONTAIGNE **IN PROGRESS**

The Complete Essays

Q4 core. Browse, don't rush. Keep dipping in daily throughout both years.

WILLIAM FAULKNER **IN PROGRESS**

The Sound and the Fury

Q7 material — reading ahead. Finish it, then go straight to Absalom, Absalom!

ROBERT CARO **IN PROGRESS**

The Path to Power (LBJ Vol. 1)

Q5 Tier II. Your history reading for the next two months.

SHELBY FOOTE **FRONT-LOADED**

The Civil War: A Narrative — Vol. I

Front-loaded per request. The American Iliad. Second-hour reading running alongside everything else. Vols. II & III continue through Q6 and Q7.

ALEXANDRE DUMAS **IN PROGRESS**

The Count of Monte Cristo

Tier II pleasure novel. Your evening reading when the primary texts are heavy.

CHARLES DICKENS

IN PROGRESS

Oliver Twist

Tier II. Run alongside Monte Cristo.

CHEKHOV · WODEHOUSE

ALWAYS

Short Stories

Tier IV forever. Never stop.

MIT PYTHON · THOMAS SOWELL

IN PROGRESS

Introduction to CS · Basic Economics

Tech track and Tier III. Python daily 20–30 min. Sowell read alongside history texts.

TUTOR'S PREFACE — IN THE SPIRIT OF HAROLD BLOOM

*You are already reading. This is the first and most important fact about your education. The Oresteia is in your hands. The Bible is open. Faulkner is giving you difficulty, which means he is giving you something real. **Do not stop any of it to "begin" a curriculum. You have already begun.***

*The science curriculum has been added as a parallel strand — one science book always in progress alongside the main literary track. This is how it was done at Chicago, Harvard, and Oxford: not a separate science course but an integrated education in which **Darwin sits beside Plato, Feynman beside Shakespeare, Aldo Leopold beside Montaigne.** The greatest minds of the 20th century read across these disciplines without apology, and so should you. A Mathematician's Apology and The Peregrine are as important to your education as any novel on this list.*

Walpola Rahula's What the Buddha Taught is your Buddhist scholarly entry point. Shelby Foote's Civil War Vol. I is front-loaded as you asked. J.A. Baker's The Peregrine can be read in any quarter — it will change how you see.

BUDDHIST & CONTEMPLATIVE PHILOSOPHY STRAND — BOTH YEARS

*Runs alongside the main curriculum. **Buddhism and Greek philosophy are asking the same questions** and arriving at different answers. Read them in parallel. Begin with Rahula — the scholarly entry point, not a popular introduction.*

● BEGIN MONTH 1

WALPOLA RAHULA

What the Buddha Taught

A Theravada monk with a doctorate from the Sorbonne. Brief, clear, authoritative. The Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, the nature of the self — without sentimentality. One week. Start here before anything else in the Buddhist strand.

THE DHAMMAPADA (PENGUIN CLASSICS)

The Dhammapada — one chapter daily

423 verses. Read one chapter per day alongside your other reading throughout both years. The opening verse: "Mind is the forerunner of all actions." Read alongside Job and notice two ancient traditions asking the same question.

● TIER II — YEAR ONE INTO YEAR TWO

BHIKKHU BODHI (TRANS.)

In the Buddha's Words

The definitive Pali Canon anthology in English. Your scholarly foundation after Rahula.

SHANTIDEVA

The Way of the Bodhisattva — Chapter VI (Patience)

Read Chapter VI alongside Marcus Aurelius. Both writing about responding to anger without being destroyed by it. The Buddhist and Stoic answers differ; the question is identical.

NAGARJUNA (TRANS. JAY GARFIELD)

Mulamadhyamakakarika — Fundamental Verses on the Middle Way

Graduate-level Buddhist metaphysics — you already have it. Read after Rahula and Bodhi. Nagarjuna: nothing exists independently; everything arises in dependence on other things. Read alongside Plato's Parmenides — two of the greatest philosophical minds thinking about the same problem from opposite starting points.

SURENDRANATH DASGUPTA (YOU HAVE IT)

A History of Indian Philosophy Vol. I

Use as scholarly context for the Buddhist primary texts throughout.

PETER MATTHIESSEN

The Snow Leopard

A journey into the Himalaya in search of the snow leopard — and simultaneously a Buddhist meditation on grief, impermanence, and attention. Belongs in both the science strand (ornithology, natural history) and the Buddhist strand.

● TIER IV — DIP THROUGHOUT

D.T. SUZUKI · SHUNRYU SUZUKI · CHOGYAM TRUNGPA ·
KORNFIELD · GOLDSTEIN

Intro to Zen Buddhism · Zen Mind Beginner's Mind · Cutting Through Spiritual Materialism · Path With Heart · Experience of Insight

Dip in throughout both years. You already have all of these. Trungpa pairs with Nietzsche on self-deception.

I

YEAR ONE · 2026

Sacred, Greek, Roman, Medieval, Renaissance

MONTHS 1-3 · JANUARY THROUGH MARCH

Q1 — The Sacred & The Carnavalesque

The Bible. Rabelais. Gilgamesh. Shelby Foote Vol. I. Buddhist strand begins. Science: Gilbert White and Euclid.

● TIER I — DEEP READ

THE BIBLE (KJV) — CONTINUING

Job · Genesis · Exodus · Psalms · Ecclesiastes · Song of Solomon · Mark · John · Romans · Revelation

Job first, always. The oldest text in the Bible and the most modern in sensibility. Read Psalms aloud. Ecclesiastes is the most honest book ever written. Read the Gospels as literature: Mark is urgent; John is literary.

RABELAIS (M.A. SCREECH TRANS.)

Gargantua and Pantagruel — Books I, II, III

Read in alternation with the Bible — one hour each. Rabelais invented the essay, the satirical novel, and the carnivalesque mode. Do not skip the lists — the lists are the argument.

ANONYMOUS (PENGUIN)

The Epic of Gilgamesh

One sitting. 4,000 years old. The flood narrative predates Noah by a thousand years. Read alongside Genesis.

● SCIENCE TRACK — Q1

GILBERT WHITE

The Natural History of Selborne

One letter per day alongside the primary reading. The founding text of ecology — and one of the most beautiful books in English prose. Darwin said it taught him how to observe. A curate in a Hampshire village, thirty years of patient attention. Begin here and the whole natural world will start to come into focus.

EUCLID

Elements — Books I & II

Chicago's Great Books program required Euclid alongside Homer and Plato. Books I and II take about three weeks at one proposition per day. Lincoln taught himself Euclid to learn how to construct an argument. The model for all rigorous reasoning.

ROGER TORY PETERSON

A Field Guide to the Birds

Begin using this in the field now. The practice of identifying birds is a practice in the careful observation that the best scientists and writers share. Keep it with you throughout both years.

● BUDDHIST STRAND — BEGIN

WALPOLA RAHULA

What the Buddha Taught

One week. The scholarly entry point. See Buddhist strand section above.

THE DHAMMAPADA

One chapter daily — throughout both years

Begin now, continue every day.

TECH TRACK — Q1

In Progress: MIT Python — keep going, 3 sessions/week, 30 min each

Mathematics: Begin Mathematics for Machine Learning (Deisenroth)
— linear algebra chapters

Goal by March: Comfortable Python fundamentals. Understand
vectors and matrices

MONTHS 4-6 · APRIL THROUGH JUNE

Q2 — Homer & the Greek World

*Finish the Oresteia. The Iliad. The Odyssey. Sophocles. Thucydides.
Science: Thoreau's Walden. Mathematics: G.H. Hardy.*

● FINISH THIS QUARTER

AESCHYLUS

FINISH FIRST

The Oresteia

Finish it. Read all three plays in one long weekend if possible. The trilogy must be read as one work.

J.B. BURY

IN PROGRESS

A History of Greece

Keep reading as contextual history for the whole quarter.

● TIER I — DEEP READ

HOMER (CHAPMAN'S — YOU HAVE THE PRINCETON/BOLLINGEN SET)

The Iliad

Read aloud when alone. Mark every simile — in the midst of carnage Homer pauses to describe a bee, a river, a woman weaving. The contrast between the simile's peace and the battle's violence is the poem's moral argument.

HOMER (FAGLES OR LATTIMORE)

The Odyssey

After the Iliad this reads like a novel. Books IX-XI are the essential core.

SOPHOCLES (FAGLES)

Oedipus Rex · Oedipus at Colonus · Antigone

Oedipus Rex is the perfect tragedy. Read Antigone immediately after — the two plays ask the same question and reach opposite answers. The founding argument of Western political thought, dramatized better than any philosopher has managed.

THUCYDIDES

History of the Peloponnesian War

Books II and V essential. The Melian Dialogue: ten pages that changed political thought permanently.

● TIER II

HERODOTUS (FOLIO SOCIETY — YOU HAVE IT)

The Histories

The first historian, first travel writer, first ethnographer. Read as a novel. Books VII-VIII are the dramatic core.

EURIPIDES (PENGUIN)

Medea · The Bacchae

The first modern playwright. Read after Sophocles for the contrast.

● TIER III — ENCOUNTER (GREECE & ROME SECONDARY READING)

H.D.F. KITTO

The Greeks

The best short introduction to Greek civilization ever written. Read alongside Homer.

EDITH HAMILTON

The Greek Way

Required at dozens of American universities through the 1960s. The Roman Way follows in Q3.

M.I. FINLEY

The Ancient Greeks

More rigorous than Hamilton. Read the chapters on the polis and democracy.

HERACLITUS (TRANS. BROOKS HAXTON)

Fragments

One hour. "You cannot step in the same river twice." Read alongside the Dhammapada — Heraclitus and the Buddha were contemporaries, both thinking about impermanence.

● SCIENCE TRACK — Q2

HENRY DAVID THOREAU

Walden

One chapter per day alongside the Greeks. Thoreau spent two years in a cabin by a pond and wrote the most influential piece of American prose about nature and how to live. It is also philosophy: what is essential, what can be discarded. Read it slowly.

G.H. HARDY

A Mathematician's Apology

The most beautiful short book about mathematics ever written. Hardy defends pure mathematics as an art form. Written when he felt his powers fading — the most honest professional autobiography in any discipline. Required at Cambridge. Read in one afternoon.

TECH TRACK — Q2

Statistics: Introduction to Statistical Learning (James et al.) Chapters 1-4

Applied: Begin Hands-On Machine Learning (Géron) — train your first model end-to-end

Latin: Wheelock's Grammar Chapters 1-15. 20 min/day

MONTHS 7-9 · JULY THROUGH SEPTEMBER

Q3 — Plato, Aristotle, Rome & the Stoics

The Republic. The Ethics. Virgil's Aeneid. The Stoics. Caesar. I, Claudius. Science: Henry Beston, Pólya, Lyell selections.

● TIER I — DEEP READ

PLATO (ADAM'S CAMBRIDGE ED. — YOU HAVE BOTH VOLUMES)

The Republic

The most important book in Western thought — not because it is right but because everything subsequent is arguing with it. Take six weeks. Mark everything you disagree with. The education is in the disagreement.

PLATO

Symposium · Apology · Phaedo · Gorgias

The Symposium first — Plato at his most literary. The Apology and Phaedo together: a man on trial for his ideas, then dying for them without regret. The most moving philosophical text ever written.

ARISTOTLE (HACKETT)

Nicomachean Ethics · Poetics

The Ethics: what is the good life? Virtue, community, luck. The Poetics in one afternoon — read it after the Greek plays.

VIRGIL (FAGLES)

The Aeneid

Books I, II, IV, VI, XII essential. Book VI (the underworld) is the most influential single book in the Latin canon — Dante could not have written the Comedy without it.

● TIER II — THE STOICS & AUTOBIOGRAPHERS OF POWER

MARCUS AURELIUS

Meditations

The most honest book a powerful man has ever written. Read one or two entries per day. The man running an empire fighting every day not to become the kind of man that power makes you. Read alongside Shantideva's Chapter VI on patience.

SENECA

Letters from a Stoic · On the Shortness of Life

Written while waiting for Nero's execution order. On the Shortness of Life in one sitting: you are not running out of time; you are wasting the time you have.

EPICTETUS

The Enchiridion · Discourses (selected)

A freed slave who became the most influential Stoic teacher. The Enchiridion in one sitting. Some things are in your power; some are not. Everything follows from this distinction.

JULIUS CAESAR

The Gallic War · The Civil War

Caesar writing about himself in the third person. Also the simplest classical Latin prose — read key passages in Latin alongside English.

ROBERT GRAVES

I, Claudius · Claudius the God

The finest historical novel in English. Graves reconstructed the Julio-Claudians from Suetonius and Tacitus and put it in the mouth of Claudius. Required at several Oxbridge colleges in the 1960s alongside the primary sources.

PLUTARCH (PENGUIN)

Lives: Alexander · Caesar · Cicero · Pericles · Alcibiades · Brutus

Six lives. Shakespeare read Plutarch — read the Life of Caesar alongside the play and see exactly what he took and what he transformed.

● TIER III — ENCOUNTER

SUETONIUS · TACITUS (ANNALS I-VI) · BOETHIUS

The Twelve Caesars · The Annals · The Consolation of Philosophy

Suetonius: the gossip Tacitus refuses to tell you. Tacitus: the most acute political historian of antiquity. Boethius: the most-read book in medieval Europe after the Bible — written in prison awaiting execution. Read in a day before Dante.

AQUINAS (TRANS. RICHARD J. REGAN)

Commentary on Aristotle's Politics · Commentary on Aristotle's Physics (Dumb Ox Books)

Aquinas as Aristotle's medieval interpreter — essential for understanding how Greek philosophy was absorbed and transformed by Catholic theology. Read

alongside the Nicomachean Ethics you have already covered. The Politics commentary belongs in Q3; the Physics in Q4 alongside Dante.

DIONYSIUS THE AREOPAGITE

The Complete Works — Selected (3-vol. collection)

The great 5th century mystical theologian whose writings shaped medieval Christian thought more than almost any other figure. Dante placed him in Paradiso. Without Dionysius you cannot fully understand Dante's conception of light, hierarchy, and the ascent toward God. Read selections alongside Paradiso.

REGINALD GARRIGOU-LAGRANGE

Reality: A Synthesis of Thomistic Thought

The 20th century's finest systematic exposition of Thomism — Aquinas's philosophy laid out with rigour and clarity. Required reading in Catholic universities and seminaries throughout the 20th century. Use as a reference alongside the Aquinas primary texts.

R.H. BARROW · EDITH HAMILTON · THEODOR MOMMSEN

The Romans · The Roman Way · History of Rome (selected)

Barrow and Hamilton: the best short accounts of Roman civilization.

Mommsen: the great 19th century narrative, Nobel Prize 1902. Read the Republic books as your framework for Caesar.

● SCIENCE TRACK — Q3

HENRY BESTON

The Outermost House

A year alone in a dune cottage on Cape Cod, 1928. The finest book of nature writing in the American tradition after Thoreau. Read alongside the Stoics — Beston's solitude is a form of philosophical practice.

GEORGE PÓLYA

How to Solve It

Pólya's guide to mathematical problem-solving — really a guide to thinking. The heuristics apply equally to writing, engineering, and diagnosis. Required at Stanford for decades. Read in a week.

CHARLES LYELL

Principles of Geology — Introduction + Chapters 1-5

Darwin read this on the Beagle. Lyell established that the Earth is vastly older than scripture suggested and that the same geological forces that shaped the past are shaping the present. The conceptual prerequisite for Darwin.

TECH TRACK — Q3

Applied ML: Hands-On Machine Learning (Géron) Chapters 1-9. Train classifiers. Build a neural network

First real project: Build a text classifier on a domain you care about. Train, evaluate, deploy it

Spanish: Pimsleur Spanish I + Assimil. 20 min/day

MONTHS 10-12 · OCTOBER THROUGH DECEMBER

Q4 — Medieval, Renaissance & Political Philosophy

Dante. Chaucer. Cervantes Part I. Machiavelli. Hobbes. Science: Aldo Leopold, Courant & Robbins, Frazer, Wendell Berry.

● TIER I — DEEP READ

DANTE (KIRKPATRICK — ALL 3 VOLS.)

The Divine Comedy: Inferno · Purgatorio · Paradiso

Three cantos per session. Inferno in one month. Do not skip Purgatorio or Paradiso. Read with Boethius fresh in your mind — the Consolation is the philosophical scaffolding of the whole Comedy.

CERVANTES

Don Quixote — Part I

The novel is born here. Comedy and tragedy are simultaneous — that is what the novel can do that no other form can.

ALDO LEOPOLD

A Sand County Almanac

The founding text of modern environmental ethics. Leopold invented the concept of "the land ethic" — human beings have moral obligations to the natural community, not just to other people. Required in ecology, philosophy, and environmental studies at every major university since 1949. Read it month by month alongside the main curriculum — the structure of the book follows the seasons.

● TIER II

CHAUCEER (SKEAT'S OXFORD — YOU HAVE ALL 7 VOLS.)

The Canterbury Tales — General Prologue + 6 Tales

General Prologue + Knight's, Miller's, Wife of Bath's, Pardoner's, Franklin's, Nun's Priest's. Read the Prologue aloud in Middle English.

MACHIAVELLI (OXFORD WORLD'S CLASSICS)

The Prince · Discourses on Livy

The Prince in one sitting. The Discourses over two weeks — where Machiavelli's real thought lives.

EDMUND SPENSER (YOU HAVE IT)

The Faerie Queene — Books I & II

Books I and II are the essential reading. The full six books belong to the reserve.

THOMAS HOBBS

Leviathan — Parts I & II

The foundation of modern political philosophy. Required alongside Machiavelli at all major universities through the 1970s.

● TIER III — ENCOUNTER

AUGUSTINE · FRANCES YATES · BOCCACCIO

Confessions · The Art of Memory (Ch. 1-6) · Decameron (20 tales)

Augustine: the first autobiography — read before Dante. Yates: how Dante's Comedy works as a memory palace. Boccaccio: the Italian complement to Chaucer, written the same decade.

AUGUSTINE

City of God — Selected Books (I-II, XI, XIX)

Augustine's great political theology — the two cities, earthly and divine, and the relationship between Christian faith and political order. Books I-II (Rome's fall), XI (creation and time), and XIX (peace and justice) are the essential selections. Required in medieval studies courses everywhere. Read alongside Dante.

POPE LEO XIII · ED. ETIENNE GILSON

The Church Speaks to the Modern World: The Social Teachings of Leo XIII

Leo XIII's great encyclicals — *Rerum Novarum* chief among them — constitute the Catholic Church's response to industrial capitalism and the social question. Essential for understanding the political theology tradition running from Aquinas through to 20th century Catholic thought. Gilson's editorship gives it exactly the right scholarly frame.

PETER DE ROO

Material for a History of Pope Alexander VI, His Relatives and His Time — Vol. I: Family De Borgia (1924)

The serious scholarly account of the Borgias — the most notorious papal family, whose excesses scandalized even Renaissance Italy. Read alongside I, Claudius for the parallel: both are accounts of a dynasty in which power corrupts spectacularly. De Roo is the corrective to popular mythology; rigorous and primary-source based.

JOHN ADDINGTON SYMONDS

Renaissance in Italy: The Catholic Reaction

Symonds's magisterial account of the Counter-Reformation and its cultural consequences — the Church's response to Protestant challenge reshaping Italian art, literature, and intellectual life. Essential context for understanding Dante's world in retrospect and the Renaissance material in Q4-Q5.

JAMES GEORGE FRAZER

The Golden Bough — Abridged Edition (selected chapters)

The most influential work of comparative anthropology ever written. Eliot used it to write The Waste Land. Joyce used it to write Ulysses. Required at every major university 1900-1970. Read the chapters on the dying and rising god, the scapegoat, and the sacred king. You will recognise these patterns everywhere once you have seen them.

WENDELL BERRY (YOU HAVE IT)

The World-Ending Fire — Selected Essays

Read alongside Aldo Leopold. Berry is the great American writer on human communities and the land. Read "The Peace of Wild Things" first.

RICHARD COURANT & HERBERT ROBBINS

What Is Mathematics? — Selected Chapters

Einstein recommended it. The classic introduction to mathematics for the intelligent non-specialist. Read the chapters on number, geometry, and topology — not as techniques but as ideas. Required in many university general education programmes.

DESMOND MORRIS

The Naked Ape

Morris's 1967 account of human beings as a species of primate. A bestseller that changed how educated people thought about human nature. Read alongside Frazer for the longer anthropological view.

TECH TRACK — Q4

ML systems: Introduction to Statistical Learning — complete remaining chapters

Goal by December: Have deployed a real ML model. Know the full pipeline: data → model → deployment

Spanish: Continue Pimsleur. Beginning to read simple Spanish texts

II

YEAR TWO · 2027

The Modern Canon — Shakespeare Through Joyce

MONTHS 13-15 · JANUARY THROUGH MARCH

Q5 — Shakespeare, Milton & the Men of Action

Shakespeare. Cervantes Part II. Paradise Lost. Napoleon. Boswell. Tocqueville. Burke. Darwin. Feynman. Einstein. Butterfield.

BLOOM'S NOTE

*Shakespeare is the center of the Western literary canon. Not Homer, not Dante — **Shakespeare**. He invented the human as we understand it: the self that overhears itself, that changes through self-reflection. Read at least one play aloud, even alone — these are scripts, not poems; they require the breath.*

● TIER I — DEEP READ

SHAKESPEARE (COMPLETE WORKS)

Hamlet · King Lear · Macbeth · Othello · The Tempest · Measure for Measure

One play per two-and-a-half weeks. Hamlet first — the modern mind begins here. King Lear last — by the time you reach it your eyes should be ready for what it costs.

CERVANTES

Don Quixote — Part II

The first metafiction — the characters know they are in a novel. This is Borges and Nabokov, written in 1615. The ending is among the most heartbreaking in all literature.

MILTON (FOWLER'S ROUTLEDGE ED.)

Paradise Lost

Books I, II, IV, IX essential. Satan is the first modern hero — ambitious, self-created, magnificent, and wrong. Blake thought Milton was unconsciously on Satan's side. He may have been right.

CHARLES DARWIN

The Origin of Species

Harvard, Chicago, and Oxford all required this as a primary text for everyone. The argument is one of the great achievements of human prose reasoning. Read Introduction, Chapters I, III, IV, XIV. "There is grandeur in this view of life..." Read alongside Dawkins immediately after.

● TIER II — MEN OF ACTION & POLITICAL PHILOSOPHY

NAPOLEON BONAPARTE · ANDREW ROBERTS (YOU HAVE IT)

Napoleon's Maxims of War · Selected Letters · Roberts's Napoleon

Napoleon writing about war and power is primary text — not secondary reading. His maxims are a philosophy of action. Read Roberts as the frame; Napoleon's own words as the substance.

ALEXIS DE TOCQUEVILLE

Democracy in America — Vol. I + Selected Vol. II Chapters

The greatest book ever written about America — by a Frenchman who spent nine months here. Tocqueville predicted everything. Required everywhere through the 1970s.

EDMUND BURKE

Reflections on the Revolution in France

Written 1790, before the Terror. More frightening read after the Terror — because Burke predicted it.

JAMES BOSWELL (YOU HAVE IT)

The Life of Samuel Johnson

The greatest biography in the English language. Boswell invented modern biography.

BENVENUTO CELLINI

Autobiography

The most outrageous autobiography in any language. Goethe said it was the fullest portrait of a man he had ever read.

● SCIENCE TRACK — Q5

RICHARD DAWKINS

The Selfish Gene

Read immediately after Darwin. Dawkins reformulates Darwinian evolution at the level of the gene and introduces the concept of the meme. The finest work of science writing of the late 20th century. Together Darwin and Dawkins constitute the two essential texts in the life sciences.

RICHARD FEYNMAN

The Feynman Lectures Vol. I — Chapters 1-6 · Surely You're Joking, Mr. Feynman!

Chapters 1-6 of the Lectures give you what physics is trying to do and why it is beautiful — without requiring calculus. Surely You're Joking is the autobiography and the most enjoyable science book of the 20th century. Required at Caltech; imitated everywhere.

ALBERT EINSTEIN

Relativity: The Special and General Theory

Einstein's own popular exposition, written for the general reader. The argument that space and time are not absolute — explained by the man who discovered it. Required at Chicago and Harvard as a primary text.

HERBERT BUTTERFIELD

The Origins of Modern Science — Selected Chapters

The argument: the Scientific Revolution was not a discovery of new facts but a change in the way people thought about facts. Required at Cambridge through the 1970s.

TECH TRACK — Q5

Deep Learning: Deep Learning for Coders (Howard/Gugger) — build and fine-tune neural networks

Transformers: Begin LLM Engineer's Handbook — transformer architecture, attention mechanisms

Goal by March: Have fine-tuned a small language model on custom data

MONTHS 16-18 · APRIL THROUGH JUNE

Q6 — The 19th Century at Full Force

Dostoevsky. Tolstoy. Flaubert. Goethe. Balzac. Zola. Melville. George Eliot. Science: E.O. Wilson, Kuhn, Lévi-Strauss, Oliver Sacks, Watson & Crick.

● TIER I — DEEP READ

DOSTOEVSKY (PEVEAR & VOLOKHONSKY) — THE COMPLETE ACADEMIC SEQUENCE

Crime and Punishment → The Brothers Karamazov → The Idiot → Demons

The canonical order followed by Oxford, Chicago, and Yale. Each novel prepares you for the next — do not read out of sequence.

① CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

COMPLETE ✓

Crime and Punishment

Done. Raskolnikov's theory, its failure, and the long descent into confession.

② THE BROTHERS KARAMAZOV

COMPLETE ✓

The Brothers Karamazov

Done. The summit. "The Grand Inquisitor" (Book V, Chapter 5) is the greatest single scene in prose fiction. Christ returns to Seville, is arrested by the Cardinal Inquisitor, says nothing — and then kisses the old man on the lips. Read this scene fifty times. It does not diminish.

③ THE IDIOT

READ NEXT

The Idiot

Next. Dostoevsky's attempt to portray a perfectly good man — Prince Myshkin — and show how the world destroys him. You need the full weight of C&P and

Brothers K to feel what Myshkin's goodness costs. The most heartbreaking of the four great novels. Begin after Monte Cristo (May 2026).

④ DEMONS (THE POSSESSED)

Demons

After *The Idiot*. The most political of the four — a revolutionary cell in a provincial town, based on a real murder. The darkest of the four and the one that reads most like prophecy about the 20th century.

TOLSTOY

Anna Karenina · The Death of Ivan Ilych

Anna Karenina is the greatest novel. The Death of Ivan Ilych in one sitting: a man discovers he is dying and discovers simultaneously that he has never lived. Read it twice in the same week.

FLAUBERT (STEEGMULLER TRANS.)

Madame Bovary · Sentimental Education

Madame Bovary: the first truly modern novel. Sentimental Education: the novel about failing to live your life, in which nothing happens for 600 pages and the reader feels the weight of every wasted year.

THOMAS KUHN

The Structure of Scientific Revolutions

The most cited academic book of the 20th century. Kuhn introduced the concept of the paradigm shift — science does not progress smoothly but through revolutionary discontinuities. Read this and you will think differently about all knowledge. Required everywhere from 1962. Read it alongside Dostoevsky — both are about the violent overthrow of a prevailing worldview.

● TIER II

GOETHE (PENGUIN)

Faust, Part One · The Sorrows of Young Werther

Werther first — invented Romanticism. Then Faust: the myth of modernity. You live in Faust's world.

BALZAC

Père Goriot · Lost Illusions · Cousin Bette

Père Goriot introduces the Comédie Humaine. Lost Illusions is Balzac's masterpiece — ambition meeting the market, a young man destroyed by the world he wanted to conquer. Cousin Bette is the most bitter; read it last.

ZOLA

Germinal · Nana

Germinal: the supreme novel of labour and class. Nana: the flesh and its consequences.

HERMAN MELVILLE

Moby-Dick

The greatest American novel. Do not skip the cetology chapters — they are the argument. Ahab is magnificent and wrong.

GEORGE ELIOT

Middlemarch

The greatest English novel. Dorothea Brooke is Eliot's argument about what Victorian England did to women of extraordinary capacity.

STENDHAL

The Red and the Black

The template for every ambitious young man in fiction since 1830. Still the sharpest political novel ever written.

● SCIENCE TRACK — Q6

CLAUDE LÉVI-STRAUSS

Tristes Tropiques

The most beautiful book ever written by an anthropologist. Lévi-Strauss's account of fieldwork in Brazil — and simultaneously a meditation on civilization and the vanishing of the world. Sartre called it "the most beautiful book of the second half of the 20th century." Read alongside the Russian novels as a different kind of account of what modernity destroys.

E.O. WILSON

On Human Nature · The Diversity of Life

On Human Nature: what does evolution imply about ethics and religion? The Diversity of Life: the most eloquent account of what we are losing ecologically.

OLIVER SACKS

The Man Who Mistook His Wife for a Hat · An Anthropologist on Mars

Neurological case histories that are simultaneously clinical documents and profound meditations on what it means to be a person. The finest medical writing of the late 20th century.

JAMES WATSON

The Double Helix

The discovery of DNA as personal narrative — ambition, competition, luck, and genuine insight. The inside view of how science actually works.

BERND HEINRICH

Mind of the Raven

Fifteen years studying raven intelligence. Heinrich is the heir to both Lorenz and Thoreau. The finest ornithological science writing since Baker's *The Peregrine*.

TECH TRACK — Q6

LLMs: Building LLMs for Production + AI Engineering (O'Reilly) — RAG pipelines, agents with tool use

Systems: Designing Data-Intensive Applications (Kleppmann) Chapters 1-5

Goal by June: Have built and deployed a working LLM-powered application

MONTHS 19-21 · JULY THROUGH SEPTEMBER

Q7 — Nietzsche, the Americans & Kafka

Nietzsche. Faulkner completed. Whitman. Kafka. Mann. Bulgakov. Science: Rachel Carson, Bronowski, Jared Diamond, Primo Levi, Hawking.

● NOW IN FULL CONTEXT — FINISH

FAULKNER

FINISH + ABSALOM

The Sound and the Fury → Absalom, Absalom!

You are reading ahead — which is correct. Finish Sound and the Fury, then immediately Absalom, Absalom! By Q7 you will have read Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, Dostoevsky, Tolstoy — and Absalom will read entirely differently for it.

SHELBY FOOTE

VOL. III

The Civil War Vol. III

The final volume. The exhaustion of the war, the death of Lincoln. Vol. III ends on a note no reader forgets.

● TIER I — DEEP READ

FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE

Genealogy of Morals · Thus Spoke Zarathustra · Untimely Meditations

Genealogy first — the most dangerous book of the 19th century. Then Zarathustra: not philosophy but poetry. Untimely Meditations last: his critique of historical consciousness, which is also a critique of you reading this syllabus. Take it seriously.

RACHEL CARSON

Silent Spring · The Sea Around Us

Silent Spring (1962) changed the world — one book that altered government policy, public consciousness, and the fate of species. Required reading everywhere after 1962. The Sea Around Us is Carson at her most lyrical. Read them alongside Nietzsche — one destroys old complacencies, the other builds new ones.

● TIER II

WALT WHITMAN

Leaves of Grass — Song of Myself · Crossing Brooklyn Ferry

Read "Song of Myself" aloud — all 52 sections. Whitman invented a voice that had never existed before: the democratic self that contains all other selves.

KAFKA

The Trial · The Metamorphosis

The Trial in one week. Read as realism, not allegory. The Metamorphosis in one sitting; again the next morning.

BULGAKOV

The Master and Margarita

Satan visits Soviet Moscow. Profoundly funny, metaphysically serious. Read in one long weekend.

THOMAS MANN

The Magic Mountain

Two characters argue Fascism and Liberalism across 800 pages while the protagonist does nothing decisive. Written before 1924. The most prophetic novel of the 20th century.

SHELBY FOOTE — CIVIL WAR VOL. II

The Civil War Vol. II — Fredericksburg to Meridian

Vicksburg and Gettysburg in the same week — the greatest week in American history, narrated by its greatest chronicler.

● SCIENCE TRACK — Q7

JACOB BRONOWSKI

The Ascent of Man

The finest popular history of science and human intellectual development ever written. From the first stone tools through Newton, Darwin, and Einstein, Bronowski traces the development of human knowledge as a continuous act of imagination. The final chapter — at Auschwitz — is one of the most devastating passages in 20th century prose. Read it and you will know what science is for.

JARED DIAMOND

Guns, Germs and Steel

Why some civilizations came to dominate others — not through superiority but through geographical accidents. The most important book of popular science of the late 20th century. Read alongside the histories of empire you have already encountered.

PRIMO LEVI

The Periodic Table

Levi was a chemist and a survivor of Auschwitz. He organizes his autobiography around the chemical elements — each chapter named for a substance that shaped or illuminated an episode in his life. The most beautiful book ever written about chemistry, and one of the most beautiful memoirs in any language. It belongs in both the science strand and the literature track.

STEPHEN HAWKING

A Brief History of Time

Black holes, the Big Bang, the arrow of time. Read after Einstein and Feynman for the context. Still the best popular account of modern cosmology.

VACLAV SMIL (YOU HAVE IT)

Energy and Civilization: A History

All of human history as the successive capture of new energy sources. Required in energy policy and environmental studies. Read alongside Rachel Carson.

TECH TRACK — Q7

Specialization: Choose your domain: NLP, computer vision, or RL. Go deep on one. Read foundational papers

MLOps: Introducing MLOps (O'Reilly) — monitoring, retraining, data pipelines at scale

Goal by September: Portfolio of 3 real projects. Ready to contribute to or lead a technical team

MONTHS 22-24 · OCTOBER THROUGH DECEMBER

Q8 — Nabokov, World Literature & Ulysses

Nabokov. Proust Vol. I. The Japanese tradition. And at the very end: Joyce's Ulysses. Science: J.A. Baker's The Peregrine. Anthropology: Matthiessen's The Snow Leopard.

BLOOM'S NOTE — FINAL QUARTER

Ulysses is the summit of the Western literary tradition. *Your eyes, after two years of Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, Dostoevsky, and Faulkner, are ready. You will recognise the Homeric parallels. You will recognise the Shakespearean riffs. You will recognise what Joyce is doing with interiority because you have read Tolstoy. This is why the sequence matters.* The final word is "yes."

● TIER I — THE SUMMIT

JAMES JOYCE (OXFORD WORLD'S CLASSICS + ANNOTATIONS — YOU HAVE BOTH)

Ulysses

One episode per week with the Annotations alongside. "Calypso" (Bloom's morning) is the easiest entry. "Proteus" is the hardest — survive it and you will survive the rest. "Ithaca" — written as a catechism — is the emotional core. "Penelope" on a Sunday morning, in one sitting. The final word is "yes."

VLADIMIR NABOKOV (EVERYMAN'S)

Pale Fire · Speak, Memory

Pale Fire: formal virtuosity as the most precise instrument for expressing human loss. Speak, Memory: the greatest literary autobiography since Augustine. Every sentence demonstrates what prose can do when the writer cares about language above all else.

J.A. BAKER

The Peregrine

Published 1967. The greatest work of ornithology ever written — and one of the great works of English prose. Baker spent ten years following peregrine falcons across the Essex landscape and wrote a book of extraordinary intensity. Werner Herzog considers it essential for filmmakers. Read it in autumn, outdoors when possible. It will change how you see — which is the point of the whole education.

● TIER II — WORLD LITERATURE

MURASAKI SHIKIBU (ROYALL TYLER TRANS.)

The Tale of Genji

The world's first novel, c. 1000 CE. Read it against Proust and understand both better.

MISHIMA (VINTAGE)

The Temple of the Golden Pavilion · Spring Snow

Temple is a standalone masterpiece. Spring Snow opens the Sea of Fertility tetralogy, completed on the day Mishima died.

SŌSEKI · KAWABATA · TANIZAKI

Kokoro · Snow Country · The Makioka Sisters

The three pillars of modern Japanese fiction alongside Mishima. One per month.

MARCEL PROUST (PENGUIN MODERN CLASSICS)

In Search of Lost Time, Vol. I: Swann's Way

20 minutes before sleep every night. Vol. I is the beginning; the subsequent six volumes are your reading life for the years ahead.

MARGUERITE YOURCENAR

Memoirs of Hadrian

The greatest historical novel. By this point in the syllabus you know Hadrian's world intimately. The recognition will be extraordinary.

● SCIENCE TRACK — Q8

PETER MATTHIESSEN

The Snow Leopard

A journey into the Himalaya in search of the snow leopard — and a Buddhist meditation on grief, impermanence, and attention. It belongs simultaneously in the science strand, the ornithology/natural history strand, and the Buddhist strand. Read it in the final quarter when all three streams are fully alive in you. One of the great books of the 20th century.

GEORGE GAMOW

One Two Three... Infinity

Gamow's great synthesis of mathematics, physics, biology, and cosmology. Read in the final quarter as a consolidation of the science curriculum — it covers the whole territory with extraordinary range and pleasure.

RUTH BENEDICT · BRONISŁAW MALINOWSKI

Patterns of Culture · Argonauts of the Western Pacific

The founding texts of 20th century anthropology. Benedict: cultures have distinct personalities and no culture's values are universal. Malinowski: the founding text of participant-observation fieldwork. Both required at American and British universities from the 1930s.

● TIER III — ENCOUNTER (FINAL QUARTER)

BORGES · BECKETT · CHUANG TZU

Labyrinths (selected) · Waiting for Godot · Mystic, Moralist and Social Reformer

Borges: "Pierre Menard, Author of the Quixote" rewrites everything you have read about reading. Beckett: what comes after Joyce? Less. More silence. Chuang Tzu on the final day: the Taoist text changes how you read everything you have already read. Read it and laugh. This is the right note on which to end.

TECH TRACK — Q8

Agents & Production: AI Engineering (O'Reilly) — agents that use tools, search, and memory

Goal by December: Portfolio of 4-5 real projects. Ready to lead a technical team building AI products

Spanish: Reading Borges and Cervantes in Spanish. Two years of daily practice has brought you here

+ 1/2

Depth, Consolidation & the Reserve Library

ON THE EXTENSION

*If you want to grow to 2.5 years — and you should — the extension does three things. First, it gives breathing room: some quarters above are dense and would benefit from a slower pace. Second, it opens the great works that had to be deferred: Proust Vols. II-III, Tolstoy's War and Peace, Gibbon, Braudel, Kierkegaard. Third, it allows the science curriculum to be read more fully — **the science books deserve the same unhurried attention as the literary ones.***

EXTENSION MONTHS 25-30 · JAN-JUN 2028

Consolidation & the Great Deferrals

The works that could not fit in two years. Proust. Tolstoy's War and Peace. Gibbon. Braudel. Kierkegaard. The full Shelby Foote if not complete. Science: McPhee's Annals of the Former World, Wilson's Diversity of Life, Lorenz, full Frazer.

● TIER I — THE GREAT DEFERRALS

LEO TOLSTOY

War and Peace

The greatest novel ever written. I have said Anna Karenina is the greatest — and for two years it was the correct statement. At 2.5 years, the answer changes. You now have the patience War and Peace requires and the historical knowledge to follow what it is doing. Save it for this moment.

MARCEL PROUST

In Search of Lost Time — Vols. II & III

Continue where you began in Q8. Proust is a life's work; the extension allows you to go deeper into it before the syllabus formally closes.

SØREN KIERKEGAARD

Either/Or · Fear and Trembling · The Sickness unto Death

Either/Or is the masterpiece — a 900-page argument between the aesthetic life and the ethical life, written pseudonymously. Fear and Trembling can be read in one night; return to it repeatedly. By this point in the education you have read Plato, Aristotle, the Stoics, Nietzsche, and Augustine — Kierkegaard is the synthesis that no one else attempted.

EDWARD GIBBON

The Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire — Vols. I & II (abridged)

The greatest work of English historical prose. Chapters XV and XVI — on the rise of Christianity — are the most audacious thing in English historiography. By this point you know the Roman world intimately. Gibbon read alongside everything you have read will feel like the long view coming into focus.

JOHN MCPHEE

Annals of the Former World — Basin and Range + In Suspect Terrain

McPhee's Pulitzer Prize-winning geology of North America. The greatest work of science writing in the American tradition. Geology teaches you deep time — billions of years — and deep time changes how you read everything else. By the extension, your sense of the human timescale has been established by history; now McPhee gives you geological time to set against it.

● TIER II — EXTENSION SCIENCE

FERNAND BRAUDEL

The Mediterranean — Vol. I

The most ambitious history book of the 20th century. Geography and economics as destiny. Chapter 1 will change how you think about time.

KONRAD LORENZ

King Solomon's Ring · On Aggression

Lorenz's Nobel Prize-winning ethology. King Solomon's Ring: jackdaws, geese, and dogs written with rigour and affection. On Aggression: animal behaviour and what it implies about human violence.

E.O. WILSON

The Diversity of Life

The most eloquent account of what we are losing ecologically. Wilson at his most passionate and most precise.

ROBERT MACFARLANE

The Old Ways · Underland

MacFarlane's two masterpieces. Ancient footpaths and the deep underground. Together they complete a vision of the natural world that Gilbert White, Thoreau, and Leopold began.

PARALLEL TRACKS — RUNNING ALONGSIDE BOTH YEARS

Year One Essays

T.S. Eliot — "Tradition and the Individual Talent"

Emerson — "Circles" · "Self-Reliance"

Hazlitt — "On the Prose-Style of Poets"

Woolf — "Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown"

Orwell — "Politics and the English Language"

Keats — Letters to Bailey & George Keats

Ruskin — "The Lamp of Memory"

De Quincey — "On Knocking at the Gate in Macbeth"

Johnson — Rambler No. 4

Hume — "Of the Standard of Taste"

Year Two Essays

Sontag — "On Style"

Trilling — "The Fate of Pleasure"

Merleau-Ponty — "Cézanne's Doubt"

Heidegger — "The Origin of the Work of Art"

Paul Valéry — "The Method of Leonardo"

Gass — "The Soul Inside the Sentence"

Guy Davenport — "Geography of the Imagination"

Woolf — "Modern Fiction"

Henry James — "The Art of Fiction"

Nabokov — "Good Readers and Good Writers"

Daily Poetry — Both Years

Keats — Complete Poems

Blake — Songs of Innocence & Experience

Hopkins — Major Works (Oxford)

Herbert — Complete Poetry

Shelley — Selected Poems

Milton — Complete Shorter Poems

Whitman — Leaves of Grass

Rilke — Selected Poetry (Vintage)

Dylan Thomas — The Poems

*Lamb — "On the
Tragedies of
Shakespeare"*

*Carlyle — On Heroes
(selected lectures)*

*Borges — "Kafka and
His Precursors"*

*Cioran — "Some Blind
Alleys: A Letter"*

*Basho — Haiku
(Penguin)*

*Robert Lowell —
Collected Poems*

*The Dhammapada —
daily, both years*

The Reserve Library

Everything here has been verified against your complete catalogue across all sessions. These are your reading life for the years that follow — not failures or deferrals but the great works that require more time than 2.5 years can honestly give.

FICTION — FIRST PRIORITY

*Proust — In Search of Lost Time,
Vols. IV-VII*

Musil — The Man Without Qualities

Mann — Joseph and His Brothers

*Pynchon — Gravity's Rainbow ·
Mason & Dixon*

Gaddis — The Recognitions

DeLillo — Underworld

*Céline — Journey to the End of the
Night*

Pessoa — The Book of Disquiet

*Mishima — Sea of Fertility (Vols. II-
IV)*

*Joyce — Finnegans Wake (a life's
work)*

Beckett — The Trilogy

Hugo — Les Misérables

HISTORY & BIOGRAPHY

*Gibbon — Decline & Fall (complete,
6 vols.)*

*Braudel — The Mediterranean
(complete)*

Caro — LBJ Vols. 2-4

Freeman — R.E. Lee (4 vols.)

Spengler — Decline of the West

Hobsbawm — Age of Revolution

Mote — Imperial China 900-1800

*Spence — The Search for Modern
China*

*Evans — The Coming of the Third
Reich*

Stach — Kafka (3 vols.)

*Parker — Herman Melville: A
Biography*

*Rostovtzeff — Social & Economic
History of Rome*

PHILOSOPHY & IDEAS

Strauss/Cropsey — History of Political Philosophy

Voegelin — The New Science of Politics

Arendt — The Life of the Mind

Russell — History of Western Philosophy

Hofstadter — Gödel, Escher, Bach

Von Neumann — Theory of Games

Yates — The Art of Memory (complete)

Jaeger — Paideia (3 vols.)

Schopenhauer — Essays and Aphorisms

Guénon — The Crisis of the Modern World

Popper — The Logic of Scientific Discovery

Whitehead — Science and the Modern World

JAPANESE & EAST ASIAN

Mishima — Sea of Fertility (complete)

Kawabata — Master of Go · Thousand Cranes

Sōseki — I Am a Cat · Sanshirō · Kusamakura

Dazai — No Longer Human

Ōe — The Silent Cry

Abe — The Box Man

Kenkō / Chōmei — Essays in Idleness / Hōjōki

SCIENCE — DEEP RESERVE

Feynman Lectures — Vols. II & III (complete)

Poincaré — Science and Hypothesis

Euclid — Elements (complete)

Dobzhansky — Genetics and the Origin of Species

Ernst Mayr — What Evolution Is

Gould — The Panda's Thumb (complete essays)

E.E. Evans-Pritchard — Witchcraft, Oracles and Magic

Pauling — General Chemistry (selected chapters)

Richard Fortey — Life: A Natural History

Wrangham — Catching Fire

McPhee — Annals of the Former World (complete)

Audubon — Birds of America + Ornithological Biography

SHORT FICTION — ALWAYS OPEN

Chekhov — Complete Stories (forever)

Wodehouse — (forever, never stop)

Babel — Complete Works

Joyce — Dubliners

Carver — Cathedral · Will You Please Be Quiet

Hemingway — Complete Short Stories

Flannery O'Connor — Complete Stories

The Tale of the Heike (Tyler trans.)

Three Kingdoms — Luo Guanzhong

Confucius — Analects (complete)

Xunzi — The Complete Text

Chuang Tzu (if not done)

M.R. James — Ghost Stories of an Antiquary

Borges — Labyrinths (complete)

Katherine Mansfield — Stories

Zweig — Chess & collected stories

Kawabata — Palm-of-the-Hand Stories

*"The world today is sick to its thin blood for lack
of elemental things."*

Henry Beston · The Outermost House · 1928

2.5 Years · 2026-2028 · Literature · Philosophy · History · Sciences ·

Mathematics · Buddhist Philosophy · Technology

Begin where you already are · End with "yes" · Then begin again